

Computing Goes Beyond The Device

SRINI MADDALI | SVP – Engineering, Qualcomm India



Srini Maddali leads engineering for Qualcomm in India – which means he sits at the silicon end of the on-device AI shift the rest of the package keeps gesturing at. His view of the next 25 years is the most technically precise: intelligence moving off the cloud and onto the user, with the integrated CPU-GPU-NPU stack doing the heavy lifting. The same ambient-computing future others describe, told from inside the engine room.

How has tech evolved over the past 25 years?

Over the last 25 years, we have seen multiple large technology shifts happen in parallel: mobile computing, broadband connectivity, cloud, AI and now on-device intelligence. The industry moved from standalone computing models to highly connected and distributed platforms where compute, connectivity and intelligence work together.

What has also changed significantly is the role of the device itself. Earlier, performance was largely measured through hardware specifications. Today, the differentiation is increasingly at a platform and system level, how efficiently devices can process AI workloads, manage power, deliver low latency and create seamless user experiences across ecosystems. At Qualcomm, we have been part of this transition across connectivity, mobile,

compute and edge technologies globally. During this phase, publications like Digit helped build early technology awareness and credibility around product testing and benchmarking as India's consumer technology ecosystem was scaling rapidly.

How is tech going to transform our lives in the next 25 years?

The next phase of computing will be shaped by AI becoming more distributed, contextual and deeply integrated across devices and environments. We are moving toward a world where intelligence increasingly runs closer to the user instead of depending entirely on centralised cloud infrastructure.

As AI adoption scales globally, the industry will need to solve simultaneously for performance, latency, privacy and power efficiency. Running large-scale AI inference entirely

in the cloud will not be practical or efficient for many real-world use cases. This is where on-device AI and edge computing will become increasingly important.

Over time, we will see smartphones, PCs, vehicles, wearables and industrial systems operating as connected intelligent platforms rather than standalone devices. Advances in integrated CPU, GPU and NPU architectures will continue driving this transition. The larger shift will be that computing becomes more adaptive, ambient and embedded into everyday experiences rather than remaining device-centric.

Any message to Digit on completing 25 years?

25 years is a significant milestone in technology because the industry itself has continuously reinvented over that period. When Digit started, India was still largely viewed as a growing consumer technology market. Over time, the ecosystem evolved substantially. Today, India contributes much more deeply across software, semiconductors, AI and platform engineering, with teams here increasingly involved in designing and building technologies for global markets.

Digit has had a front-row view to that entire transition through multiple generations. Congratulations to the entire team on completing 25 years, and best wishes for the future! 



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